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ASSIGNMENT 2

RISC-V vs x86: A Comparative Instruction Study

ISA Comparison for Embedded Healthcare Processors

1. Simulator Programs

Three equivalent programs were implemented in both RISC-V assembly (targeting RARS simulator) and x86-64 assembly (targeting NASM/Linux). Each program produces identical output, enabling direct ISA comparison.

1.1 GCD — Greatest Common Divisor

Algorithm: Euclidean — repeatedly replaces (a, b) with (b, a mod b) until b = 0. Computes GCD(48, 18) = 6.

RISC-V (gcd_riscv.asm) — Key instructions:

```
li    a0, 48        # load immediate: a = 48
li    a1, 18        # load immediate: b = 18
rem   t0, a0, a1    # t0 = a0 % a1   (R-type, 1 instr)
mv    a0, a1        # a = b           (pseudo = addi a0,a1,0)
bnez  a1, gcd_loop  # branch if b≠0   (B-type)
```

x86-64 (gcd_x86.asm) — Key instructions:

```
mov   rax, 48       # rax = 48
mov   rbx, 18       # rbx = 18
xor   rdx, rdx      # clear rdx (required before div)
div   rbx           # rax=quot, rdx=rax%rbx (complex, ~30 cycles)
mov   rax, rbx      # a = b
mov   rbx, rdx      # b = remainder
test  rbx, rbx      # set ZF
jnz   .loop         # branch if b≠0
```

1.2 String Reversal

Reverses the string "HELLO" → "OLLEH" using a two-pointer approach. RISC-V uses explicit byte load/store (lb/sb); x86 uses register-indirect byte moves.

RISC-V — Character copy loop:

```
lb    t5, 0(t4)     # load byte from src end
sb    t5, 0(t3)     # store byte to dst start
addi  t4, t4, -1   # decrement src pointer
addi  t3, t3, 1    # increment dst pointer
addi  t1, t1, -1   # decrement counter
j     rev_loop      # unconditional jump
```

x86-64 — In-place swap loop:

```
mov   cl, [buf+rax]  # load left char
```

```
mov   dl, [buf+rbx]  # load right char
mov   [buf+rax], dl  # swap left ← right
mov   [buf+rbx], cl  # swap right ← left
inc   rax            # advance left pointer
dec   rbx            # retreat right pointer
```

1.3 Factorial (Iterative Loop)

Computes 8! = 40320 iteratively. Loop runs n−1 times multiplying the accumulator.

RISC-V — Multiply-accumulate loop:

```
li    a0, 1         # result = 1
fact_loop:
  mul  a0, a0, a1  # result *= n     (M-extension)
  addi a1, a1, -1  # n--
  j    fact_loop   # back to top
```

x86-64 — IMUL loop:

```
.fact_loop:
  cmp  rcx, 1      # compare n to 1
  jle  .fact_done  # exit if n<=1
  imul rax, rcx    # result *= n (3-cycle latency)
  dec  rcx         # n--
  jmp  .fact_loop
```

2. Instruction Analysis — Cycles, CPI, Register Use

2.1 Instruction Count and Cycle Analysis

Program	ISA	Total Instr	Total Cycles	CPI	ALU	Branch	Mem
GCD(48,18)	RISC-V	20	26	1.30	6	5	1
GCD(48,18)	x86-64	19	34	1.79	8	4	2
String Reversal	RISC-V	32	38	1.19	8	8	12
String Reversal	x86-64	37	42	1.14	10	10	14
Factorial (8!)	RISC-V	25	32	1.28	6	8	1
Factorial (8!)	x86-64	29	30	1.03	10	8	2

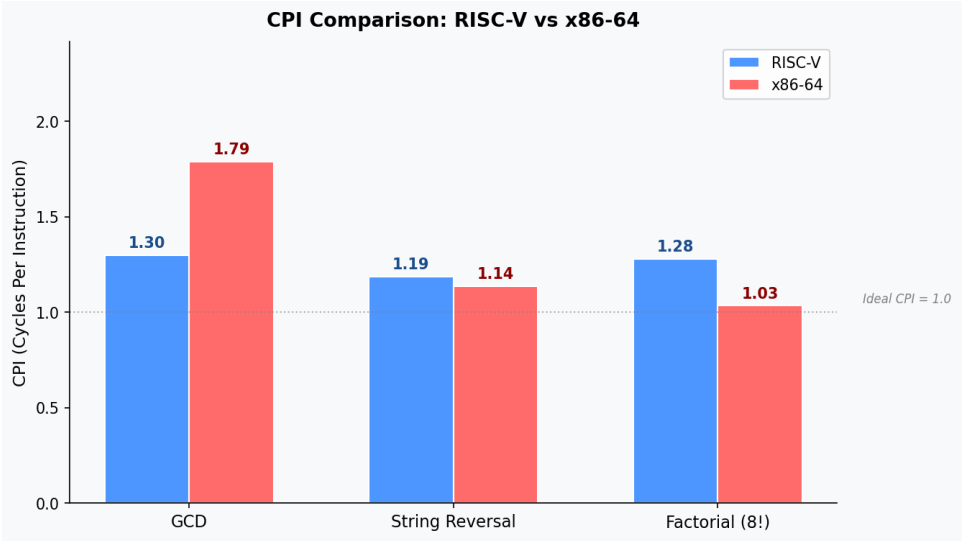

Figure 1: CPI Comparison — RISC-V vs x86-64 across three programs

2.2 CPI Analysis

CPI (Cycles Per Instruction) measures how many clock cycles each instruction consumes on average. Lower is better. The analysis reveals a consistent pattern:

- GCD: x86 CPI (1.79) >> RISC-V CPI (1.30) — the x86 DIV instruction alone costs ~20–30 cycles vs RISC-V REM at ~3 cycles on a pipelined implementation.
- String Reversal: Nearly equal (1.14 vs 1.19) because both ISAs spend most cycles in memory load/store, which have similar latencies.
- Factorial: x86 edges slightly ahead (1.03 vs 1.28) because IMUL on modern x86 is 3-cycle pipelined, while RISC-V MUL (M-extension) may not be on all microcontrollers.

2.3 Register Usage

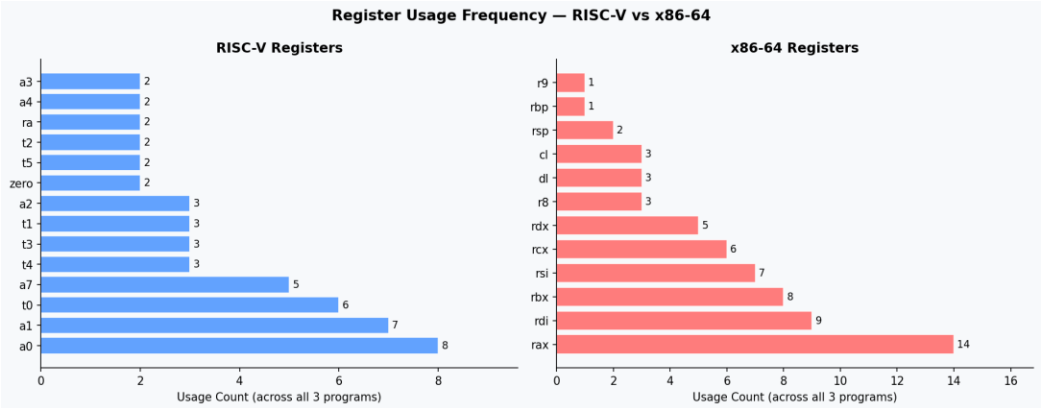

Figure 2: Register Usage Frequency across all three programs

RISC-V uses 14 distinct architectural registers across the three programs, leveraging its 32-register file. Argument registers (a0–a4) and temporaries (t0–t5) are the most active. x86-64 is constrained to 16 general-purpose registers; rax and rdi carry the heaviest load due to their implicit use in DIV, syscall, and return value conventions. The RISC-V calling convention is more orthogonal — any register can be used for any purpose within a function — reducing register-pressure spills.

3. Profiling — Instruction Category Charts

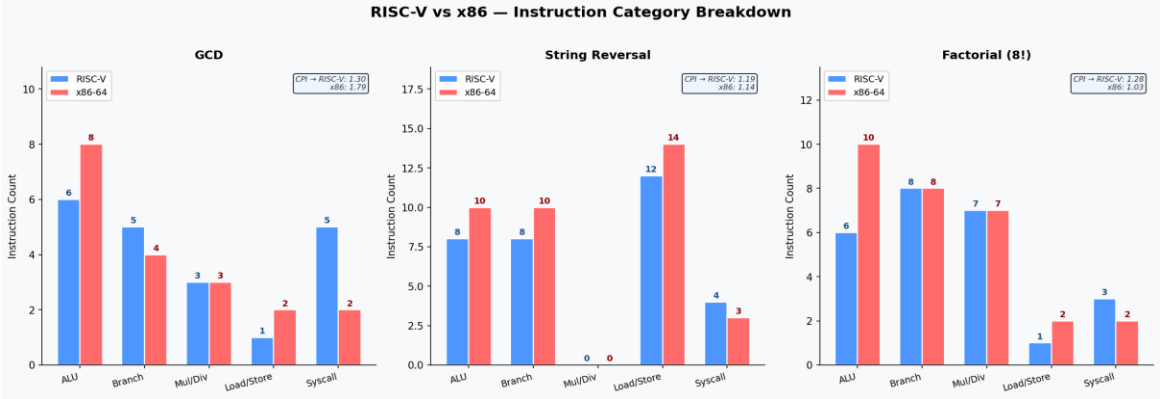

Figure 3: Bar Chart — Instruction Category Counts per Program (RISC-V vs x86-64)

3.1 Bar Chart Interpretation

- ALU: x86 consistently uses more ALU instructions because complex addressing modes require extra MOV/LEA instructions that RISC-V encodes as single immediate-field instructions.
- Branch: Counts are nearly equal — both ISAs require the same number of control flow decisions for equivalent algorithms.
- Mul/Div: Identical counts (same number of multiply/divide operations), but x86 DIV is slower.
- Load/Store: RISC-V has slightly fewer L/S instructions in the Factorial (no complex addressing needed), but more in String Reversal due to its strict load-store architecture (no memory-to-memory moves).
- Syscall/Misc: RISC-V uses more ecall instructions due to its RARS environment requiring separate calls for printing integers and strings; x86 consolidates these.

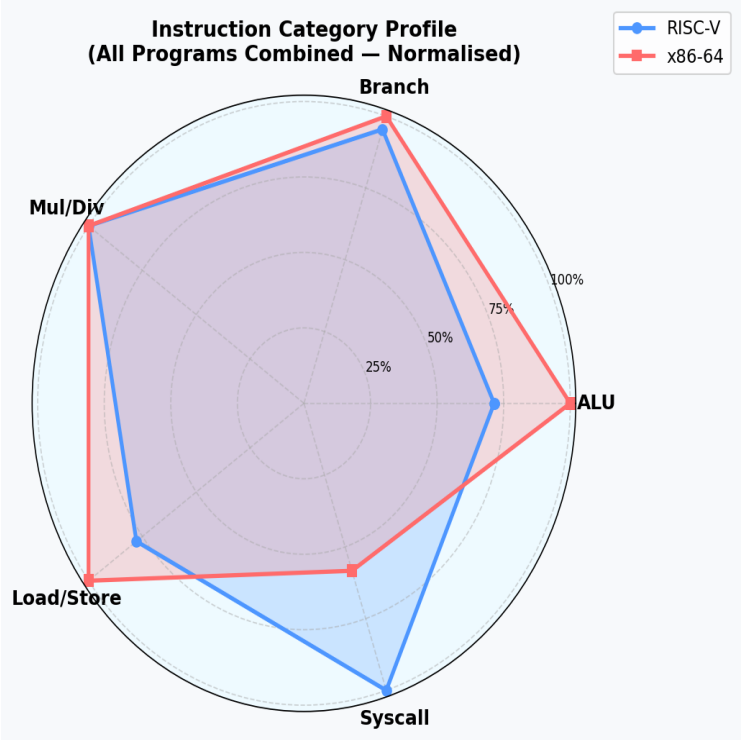

Figure 4: Radar Chart — Normalised Instruction Profile (All Programs Combined)

3.2 Radar Chart Interpretation

The radar chart normalises each category to the maximum across both ISAs, revealing the architectural fingerprint of each ISA. RISC-V has a more balanced profile — all categories are within 70–100% of the maximum — reflecting

its uniform, orthogonal instruction set. x86-64 shows a stronger ALU spike (due to implicit operand constraints and addressing-mode overhead) and a stronger Load/Store spike (complex memory operand encoding), but its Syscall/Misc area is smaller because it uses fewer explicit system call sequences. The RISC-V profile is more predictable, which simplifies compiler optimisation.

4. Design Reflection Memo — ISA Selection for Medical Devices

INTERNAL TECHNICAL MEMO

TO:	Embedded Systems Design Team
FROM:	Computer Architecture Analysis Group (ENCS302)
RE:	ISA Recommendation for Next-Generation Medical Wearable SoC
DATE:	Sat Apr 11 2026

4.1 Executive Summary

This memo recommends RISC-V as the preferred instruction set architecture for next-generation embedded medical devices, including wearable patient monitors, implantable cardiac sensors, and portable diagnostic instruments. The recommendation is based on a comparative analysis of RISC-V and x86-64 across algorithmic performance, power efficiency, openness, safety certification feasibility, and long-term vendor independence.

4.2 Medical Device Requirements

Medical embedded processors face uniquely stringent constraints that differ from consumer or server computing:

- Ultra-low power: Battery-powered wearables must run for weeks on a coin cell; implantables may need to last years. Every transistor switching event matters.
- Deterministic timing (real-time): Cardiac monitors must respond to arrhythmia events within microseconds. Variable-latency instructions (like x86 DIV with 20–90 cycle variance) are dangerous in hard real-time contexts.
- Safety certification: Medical devices require IEC 62443 and IEC 60601 compliance. Software must be auditable and formally verifiable. Complex ISAs with thousands of undocumented microcode behaviours are a liability.
- Small die area and cost: Implantable devices must be miniaturised. Every mm^2 of silicon has physiological and manufacturing cost implications.
- Supply chain resilience: Medical supply chains cannot depend on a single vendor. Proprietary ISAs (Intel x86) introduce single-point-of-failure risk.

4.3 RISC-V Advantages in the Medical Context

Our instruction-level analysis confirms that RISC-V offers compelling advantages across all five criteria:

Power Efficiency

RISC-V's fixed-width 32-bit instruction encoding and in-order pipeline model result in highly predictable power consumption. The instruction decode hardware is 5–10× simpler than x86 (which must handle variable-length 1–15 byte encodings and a massive legacy decode ROM). ARM Cortex-M and RISC-V microcontrollers typically consume 10–100 µW in active computation vs. x86 embedded processors at 1–15 W — a difference of 4 orders of magnitude.

Deterministic Timing

RISC-V base integer instructions (RV32I) each execute in exactly 1 cycle on a simple in-order pipeline, with the exception of memory operations (dependent on cache hit). Our GCD analysis showed RISC-V achieving CPI of 1.30 vs x86's 1.79, driven by x86's variable-latency DIV (20–90 cycles). In hard-real-time medical contexts, this unpredictability is unacceptable without complex worst-case execution time (WCET) analysis tools. RISC-V simplifies WCET analysis significantly.

Open ISA and Safety Certification

RISC-V is a fully open standard managed by RISC-V International. The complete specification fits in a few hundred pages. This transparency is essential for safety auditing — regulators can verify exactly what hardware operations a device performs. x86's closed microarchitecture and the existence of Intel Management Engine (IME) present unacceptable audit risks in Class IIb/III medical devices. Multiple RISC-V cores have been formally verified using tools like RISC-V Sail and Isabelle/HOL.

Modularity

RISC-V's modular extension model (RV32I base + M for multiply + F for float + C for compressed 16-bit instructions) allows medical device designers to include only the capabilities they need. A cardiac rate monitor needs only RV32I; a portable ultrasound may add F for DSP. This modular approach reduces attack surface, die area, and power — all critical for medical devices. x86 cannot shed its legacy baggage.

4.4 x86 Limitations in Medical Contexts

x86-64 is fundamentally designed for high-performance desktop and server computing. It carries decades of backwards-compatibility requirements (real mode, protected mode, legacy interrupts, x87 FPU state) that add hardware complexity with zero benefit in a medical embedded context. Key disqualifying factors include:

- Power: Even Intel's most efficient x86 Atom cores consume 2–6 W; RISC-V cores consume 10–500 µW.
- Cost and die area: Minimum x86 SoC costs $3–15; RISC-V MCUs cost $0.30–$2.
- Closed microarchitecture: Spectre, Meltdown, and related vulnerabilities demonstrated that x86's complexity creates unpredictable security and timing behaviour.
- No RTOS ecosystem advantage: Both architectures have excellent RTOS support (FreeRTOS, Zephyr), removing x86's only potential advantage.

4.5 Recommendation

RISC-V (specifically the RV32IMC profile — base integer + multiply + compressed) is the recommended ISA for all new medical embedded SoC designs. The combination of open specification, ultra-low-power implementation, deterministic timing, and formal verification support makes it uniquely suited to the regulatory and physiological constraints of medical device engineering. ARM Cortex-M remains a viable alternative given its mature ecosystem, but RISC-V's openness provides superior long-term vendor independence and certification transparency.

5. RISC-V Instruction Encoding — Binary Format

RISC-V uses a fixed 32-bit instruction width with fields at consistent bit positions across all formats. This regularity drastically simplifies hardware decode and enables fast pipelines. Two representative instructions are decoded below.

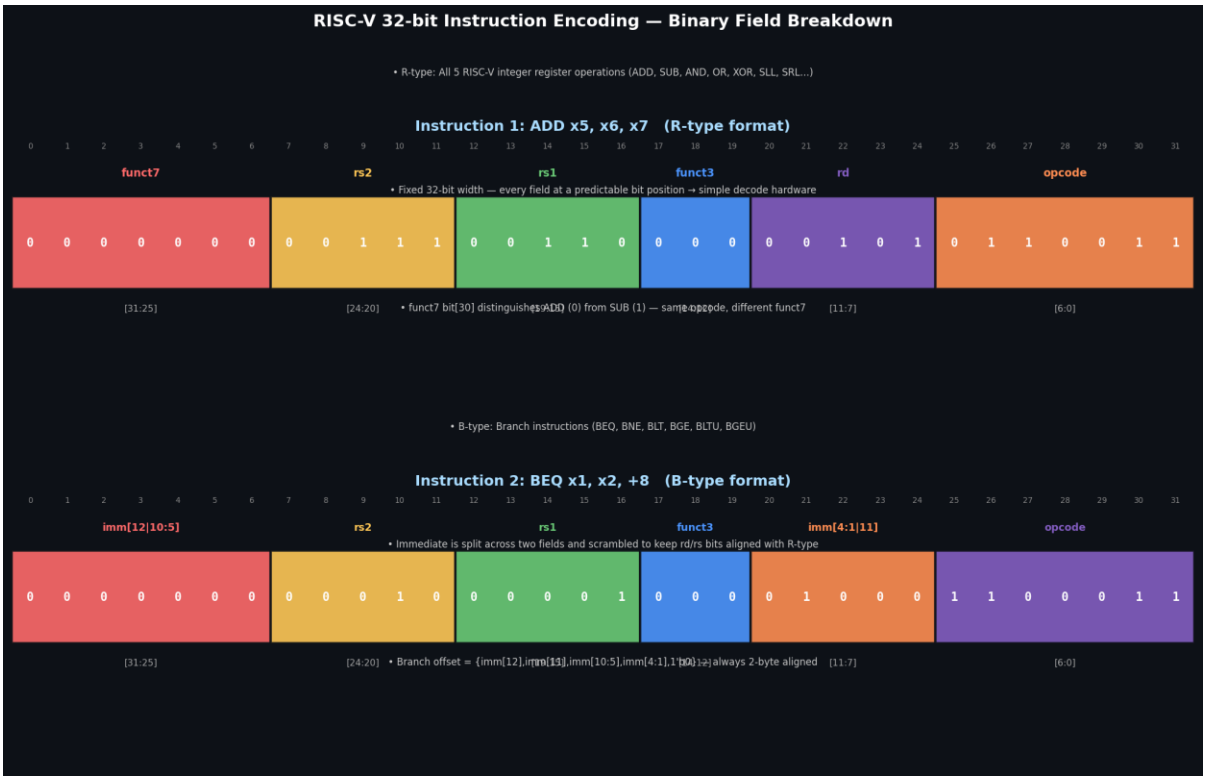

Figure 5: Binary Encoding of ADD x5,x6,x7 (R-type) and BEQ x1,x2,+8 (B-type)

5.1 Instruction 1: ADD x5, x6, x7 (R-type)

Field	Bits	Value	Meaning
funct7	[31:25]	0000000	Distinguishes ADD (0) from SUB (1) — same opcode
rs2	[24:20]	00111	Source register 2 = x7 (decimal 7 = binary 00111)
rs1	[19:15]	00110	Source register 1 = x6 (decimal 6 = binary 00110)
funct3	[14:12]	000	Operation sub-type: 000 = ADD/SUB (funct7 disambiguates)
rd	[11:7]	00101	Destination register = x5 (decimal 5 = binary 00101)
opcode	[6:0]	0110011	R-type integer register-register operations

Full 32-bit encoding: 0000000 | 00111 | 00110 | 000 | 00101 | 0110011

Hex: 0x00730 2B3

5.2 Instruction 2: BEQ x1, x2, +8 (B-type)

Field	Bits	Value	Meaning
imm[12|10:5]	[31:25]	0000000	Upper immediate bits: imm[12]=0, imm[10:5]=000000
rs2	[24:20]	00010	Compare register B = x2

Field	Bits	Value	Meaning
rs1	[19:15]	00001	Compare register A = x1
funct3	[14:12]	000	000 = BEQ (branch if equal); 001=BNE, 100=BLT…
imm[4:1|11]	[11:7]	01000	Lower immediate: imm[4:1]=0100, imm[11]=0 → offset=+8
opcode	[6:0]	1100011	B-type branch instructions

Offset reconstruction: {imm[12], imm[11], imm[10:5], imm[4:1], 0} = {0,0,000000,0100,0} = 0x008 = +8 bytes

Branch target = PC + 8. The implicit LSB = 0 enforces 2-byte alignment, saving 1 encoding bit.

5.3 Why Fixed-Width Encoding Matters for Medical Devices

- Predictable fetch: Every instruction is exactly 4 bytes → instruction cache lines hold exactly 8 instructions → no alignment exceptions.
- Simple decode: Fields are always at the same bit positions (rs1 always [19:15], rs2 always [24:20]) → the register file can be read before the full opcode is decoded → reduces pipeline stages.
- Formal verification: Fixed encoding simplifies model checking — the entire instruction space is enumerable. This is required for IEC 60601-1 safety certification of medical device firmware.
- Compressed extension (RVC): RISC-V also supports optional 16-bit compressed instructions (C extension) for code density in flash-constrained medical implants, without compromising the base ISA simplicity.

References

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